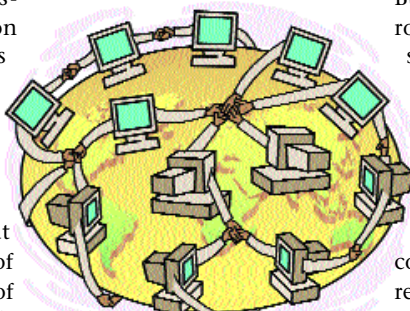


New heights in grid computing

Advanced distributed computing touched a new milestone when a grid of computers scattered at several sites in the US successfully carried out a simulation of 50,000 proton collisions as a part of the Compact Muon Solenoid Collaboration experiment. The test involved linking up systems located at Caltech, Fermilab, the University of California at San Diego, the University of Florida and the University of Wisconsin by means of a high-speed Internet connection. The success of this simulation

is important because the scientific exploration's need for computing power far outstrips what is currently available.



Globus Project and The Condor Project provided the software required to link the five

sites. The software of both these entities are open source and support Windows, Linux and all major flavours of Unix. But there are bumps on the road that have yet to be smoothed out. For instance, the heterogeneous nature of computers on the grid has to be dealt with. Besides, error recovery on a distributed system can prove to be a convoluted task. By year's end, researchers in the field of grid computing hope to widen the grid to 20 sites spanning the US and Europe.

Trespassing on the Xbox

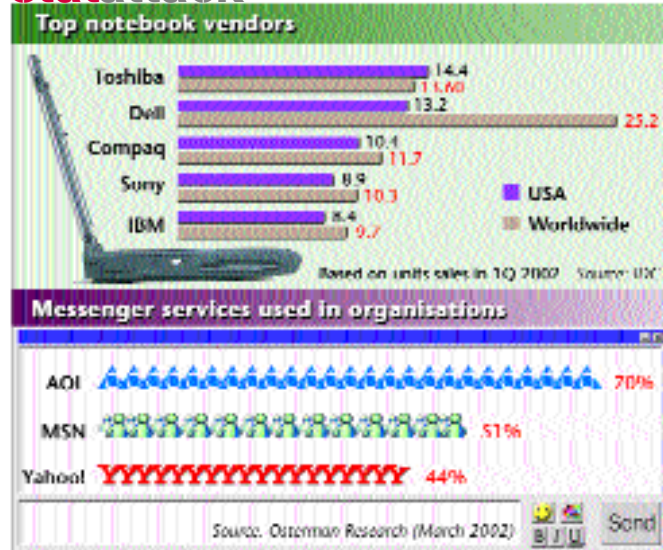
Last month saw the sale of the Xtender, a 'mod chip' that allows you to play illegally copied games on the Xbox. Customers are promised the ability to play games copied on recordable CDs and DVD discs and watch DVD movies otherwise protected by software from Macrovision. The Xtender needs to be added to the main

circuit board of the Xbox, but this is no mean feat as you need to solder it at more than 20 different spots!

Copy-protection software built into all Xbox games makes its discs unreadable on PCs. So far, only a few hacker groups have laid claim to breaking through the protection, leading to illegal game files being

traded over the Internet. Interest in these mod chips has been strongest from Europe because gamers there would no longer have to wait for six months for a PAL version (the European video standard) of the latest US game titles. While the main purpose for the mod chips is to facilitate illegal software copying, they may also be a boon to the elite hackers looking to add new software functions to the Xbox such as MP3 playback and for running emulators to play games written for older systems.

statattack



INFOGRAPHICS: Jaya Shetty

snapshot

Worldwide SMS messages to grow to **146 million** in 2002 from **102.9 billion** in 2001 and to **168 million** in 2003!

Source: Gartner Dataquest



heroes

Blue no more

Sonicblue manages to overturn order requiring it to turn over all information about what TV shows are copied, stored, viewed without commercials or traded using its ReplayTV 4000 DVR to television networks and movie studios suing it for releasing the recording device in the first place.

Spider-Man to the rescue

Sony's 1Q 2002 revenue was better than expected partly due to its hugely successful movie *Spider-Man*.



zeroes

Video piracy

The Tehran-based site www.Film88.com, which sold copyrighted films at \$1 per film over the Net, was shut down by the Motion Picture Association of America

EU's new spam guidelines

The European Parliament's new guidelines for controlling spam require telecom companies and ISPs to retain all traffic data for criminal investigation purposes. This gives the government massive power to collect private data on any EU citizen and at the same time hampers legitimate European marketers while doing little to stem junk e-mail from outside the EU member states.